SCHOOLS OF BUDDHISM

THERAPEUTIC ARCHITECTURE → DOUBLE MIDDLE PATH → TRADITIONS AND LABELS → DEPENDENT ORIGINATION → TWELVE LINKS → MOMENTARINESS → NO PERMANENT SELF → CONTINUITY → CESSATION → TWO REALISMS → IDEALISM AND EMPTINESS → KNOWING AND SILENCE → VERDICT

Read the thick cyan rail from Stage 00 to the final synthesis. Each card uses a layout chosen for its own content; the grey E card is optional enrichment only and never repairs missing core content.

● PRIMARY CORE FLOW ● SUBORDINATE EXTRA ● APPROVAL / REVIEW

Approval: FALSE • Pending user review • all prior artifacts unchanged

CORE BEFORE EXTRA • prior artefacts unchanged • exact same master drives poster and tiles

00

STAGE 00

THERAPEUTIC ARCHITECTURE AND THE THREE PRINTED TERMS

- FOUR NOBLE TRUTHS
- SUFFERING (DUḤKHA) IS
- IT HAS AN ORIGIN
- THE ORIGIN CAN CEASE
- A PATH EXISTS
- NĀSTIKA = VEDA-REJECTING, NOT ATHEIST
- NON-THEISTIC ON THE CREATOR CRITERION
- ANTI-SUBSTANTIALIST ON THE SELF CRITERION

SUFFERING IS -> IT HAS AN ORIGIN -> THE ORIGIN CAN CEASE -> A PATH EXISTS

read forward = theory of bondage · read backward = theory of liberation

THE FRAME THAT GENERATES EVERYTHING

- Syllabus item 14, verbatim: 'Schools of Buddhism : Prat Ityasamutpada; Ksanikavada, Nairatmyavada' — normalised as pratītyasamutpāda, kṣaṇikavāda, nairātmyavāda.
- Truth 1 names suffering; truth 2 gives its dependent arising; truth 3 gives dependent cessation; truth 4 gives the discipline that breaks the chain.

WHY THE THERAPY NEEDS A METAPHYSICS

- Truth 2 needs a causal theory -> dependent origination (pratītyasamutpāda).
- Truth 3 needs impermanence, since a permanent cause could not be removed -> momentariness (kṣaṇikavāda).
- Truth 4 needs a changeable person, since a permanent self could not be trained -> no permanent self (nairātmyavāda).

THREE DENIALS THAT MUST NOT BE MERGED

- Unorthodox (nāstika) = rejects Vedic authority; it does NOT mean atheist.
- Non-theistic = a creator adds no necessary explanatory work; it does NOT mean materialist.
- Anti-substantialist = no permanent self; it does NOT deny the conventional person, moral consequence, rebirth or liberation.

MECHANISM / VERDICT — The three printed syllabus terms are exactly the three metaphysical commitments the therapeutic claim requires, which is why they must be derived together and never treated as three separate topics.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Buddhism is a medical rather than a metaphysical architecture: it names a disease, isolates its cause, asserts a cure and prescribes a therapy, and every syllabus doctrine is generated inside that four-step frame.

01

STAGE 01

THE DOUBLE MIDDLE PATH AND THE EIGHTFOLD TRAINING

- MIDDLE PATH (MADHYAMĀ PRATIPAD)
- PALI: MAJJHIMĀ PAṬIPADĀ
- WISDOM (PRAJÑĀ)
- ETHICAL DISCIPLINE (ŚĪLA)
- MEDITATIVE DISCIPLINE (SAMĀDHI)
- ETERNALISM (ŚĀŚVATAVĀDA)
- ANNIHILATIONISM (UCCHEDAVĀDA)
- NOT MODERATION, NOT A MEAN

EXTREME: indulgence X MIDDLE: eightfold training X EXTREME: mortification

EXTREME: eternalism X MIDDLE: conditioned continuity X EXTREME: annihilationism → wisdom -> ethical discipline -> meditative discipline -> deeper wisdom (a loop, not a list)

PRACTICAL MIDDLE — WHAT IS REJECTED AND WHAT REPLACES IT

- Rejects sensual indulgence and self-mortification because neither removes craving; the test is causal efficacy, not balance.
- Positive content = Noble Eightfold Path (āryāṣṭāṅgamārga): right view, right intention | right speech, right action, right livelihood | right effort, right mindfulness, right concentration.

DOCTRINAL MIDDLE — THE SECOND SENSE THAT CARRIES MARKS

- Rejects eternalism (śāśvatavāda) and annihilationism (ucchedavāda); positive content = conditioned continuity without a permanent bearer.
- The shared hidden assumption denied by both extremes is that continuity requires an identical persisting thing.

STRUCTURAL TEST AND OPERATIVE TARGET

- Eternalism would defeat truth 3, because a permanent cause cannot be removed; annihilationism would defeat truth 4, because discipline would accumulate nothing.
- Insight cuts at ignorance; mindfulness cuts at the feeling-to-craving junction, since feeling is unavoidable while craving is not.

MECHANISM / VERDICT — One middle tells the practitioner how to walk and the other tells him why walking can reach anywhere at all, so an answer that gives only the practical sense has given only half the doctrine.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: The Middle Path is not moderation but double avoidance: two ways of living and two ways of thinking are refused, and each pair is replaced by a positively specified discipline rather than by a compromise.

02

STAGE 02

TRADITIONS, LABELS, CANONS AND IDEALS

- EARLY BUDDHISM
- THERAVĀDA — ONE SURVIVING SCHOOL
- PALI TIPIṬAKA
- SARVĀSTIVĀDA ORBIT
- MAHĀYĀNA
- "HĪNAYĀNA" IS AN APPLIED LABEL
- ARHAT AND BODHISATTVA IDEALS

SCHOOL	HISTORICAL PLACEMENT	PHILOSOPHICAL POSITION	DO NOT INFER
Vaibhāṣika	Sarvāstivāda Abhidharma; Kashmir Mahāvibhāṣā tradition	external dharmas real and directly perceived	that it is a branch of Theravāda
Sautrāntika	critical current in the Sarvāstivāda orbit; privileges sūtra	external objects real but inferred from representation	that it is one unified monastic institution
Yogācāra	major Mahāyāna tradition	consciousness-only; three natures; store-consciousness	that Mahāyāna equals Yogācāra
Mādhyamika	major Mahāyāna tradition	emptiness of intrinsic nature; two truths	that emptiness is sheer non-being

WHAT THE LABEL ACTUALLY IS

- 'Hīnayāna' is a Mahāyāna-applied, historically loaded classification of disciple-vehicle traditions; it was not a self-designation and is not a synonym for Theravāda.

CANON AND LANGUAGE — THE ACCURATE MINIMUM

- Theravāda preserves the Pali Tipiṭaka: Vinaya, Sutta and Abhidhamma baskets.
- Parallel early material also survives in Chinese Āgamas and Sanskrit witnesses; Sarvāstivāda and Mahāyāna works come through Sanskrit, Chinese and Tibetan transmission.

IDEALS WITHOUT CARICATURE

- Theravāda foregrounds the liberated saint (arhat; Pali arahant); Mahāyāna foregrounds the awakening being (bodhisattva) aiming at complete Buddhahood.
- These are dominant final aims, not a moral contrast: Theravāda knows the bodhisatta career and Mahāyāna knows the arhat category.

MECHANISM / VERDICT — The fourfold school matrix is a philosophical doxography used to arrange positions for comparison, and it must never be converted into a claim about the number or lineage of historical Buddhist institutions.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Placing each school correctly is itself a marks-bearing move, because Vaibhāṣika and Sautrāntika belong to the Sarvāstivāda world while Yogācāra and Mādhyamika are Mahāyāna philosophical traditions.

03

STAGE 03

DEPENDENT ORIGINATION: FORMULA, ARGUMENT AND THE THREE MARKS

- PRATĪTYASAMUTPĀDA
- QUOTE ALL FOUR CLAUSES
- IMPERMANENCE (ANITYA)
- UNSATISFACTORINESS (DUḤKHA)
- NO-SELF (ANĀTMAN)
- NO FIRST CAUSE IS CLAIMED
- NIRVĀṆA IS UNCONDITIONED (ASAṂSKṚTA)

DEPENDENCE -> NO SELF-EXISTENCE -> IMPERMANENCE → IMPERMANENCE + CAUSAL EFFICACY -> MOMENTARINESS → EXHAUSTIVE ANALYSIS UNDER MOMENTARINESS -> NO PERMANENT SELF

THE FORMULA, IN FOUR CLAUSES

- imasmiṃ sati idaṃ hoti — this being, that becomes; imass' uppādā idaṃ uppajjati — from the arising of this, that arises.
- imasmiṃ asati idaṃ na hoti — this not being, that is not; imassa nirodhā idaṃ nirujjhati — from the cessation of this, that ceases.
- The first pair states positive conditionality and the second negative conditionality, so cessation is built into the principle itself.

THE ARGUMENT, IN THE ORDER TO BE WRITTEN

- What is experienced is not self-grounding; a self-existent thing would not depend on conditions; all conditioned phenomena do depend on conditions.
- Therefore conditioned phenomena are neither eternal substances nor sheer nothingness, and suffering too is a process rather than a fate.

THE THREE MARKS AND THEIR SCOPE

- Impermanence and unsatisfactoriness are predicated of conditioned formations; no-self is applied more widely.
- Early impermanence is not verbally identical with the later one-moment thesis, and cessation of conditioned suffering is classified as unconditioned (asaṃskṛta) in important traditions.

OBJECTION AND REPLY

- Objection: an infinite regress of conditions explains nothing ultimately.
- Reply: no unconditioned substance is needed to make conditioning intelligible, because the aim is soteriological rather than genetic.

MECHANISM / VERDICT — Because cessation is stated inside the formula itself, the third Noble Truth is an entailment of dependent origination rather than a separate article of faith.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Dependent origination is not a cosmology of how the universe began but a grammar of how suffering is manufactured, and the same formula read backward is the theory of release.

04

STAGE 04

THE TWELVE LINKS AND WHERE THE CHAIN IS CUT

- DVĀDAŚA-NIDĀNA
- IGNORANCE (AVIDYĀ) HEADS THE LIST
- FEELING -> CRAVING IS THE CUT
- FORMATIONS BEFORE CONSCIOUSNESS
- CRAVING BEFORE CLINGING BEFORE BECOMING
- REVERSE ORDER (PRATILOMA)
- WHEEL OF BECOMING (BHAVA-CAKRA)

PAST CAUSES 1-2 | PRESENT RESULTS 3-7 | PRESENT CAUSES 8-10 | FUTURE 11-12 → the only OPEN box is 'present causes' — that is why a path is possible

THE SEQUENCE

- ignorance (avidyā) · formations (saṃskāra) · consciousness (vijñāna) · name-and-form (nāma-rūpa) · six sense-bases (ṣaḍāyatana) · contact (sparśa)
- feeling (vedanā) · craving (tṛṣṇā) · clinging (upādāna) · becoming (bhava) · birth (jāti) · ageing-and-death (jarā-maraṇa)

THREE LEGITIMATE READINGS

- Three-life pedagogic reading: past causes, present results, present causes, future results — it explains rebirth and karmic continuity.
- Present-process reading: contact, feeling, craving and appropriation operate now, which is what makes the chain immediately practical.
- Structural-soteriological reading: the chain diagnoses a self-sustaining pattern and can be read forward as arising and backward as cessation.

WHY IT IS NOT FATALISM

- Links eight to ten are present causes and remain open, so present practice changes what is subsequently produced.
- Ignorance heads the list without being an absolutely first cause, which is why the figure is drawn as a wheel.

MECHANISM / VERDICT — The chain contains exactly one joint at which present practice is effective, and locating that joint between feeling and craving is what separates understanding from recitation.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: The twelve links are not a chronology to be recited but a diagnosis to be used, because the reverse order converts the third Noble Truth from an assertion into a logical consequence.

05

STAGE 05

MOMENTARINESS: THE ELIMINATION ARGUMENT

- YAT SAT TAT KṢAṆIKAM
- SAT = ARTHAKRIYĀ-SAMARTHA
- SIMULTANEITY HORN (YAUGAPADYA)
- SUCCESSION HORN (KRAMA)
- SAHAKĀRI-ANAPEKṢĀ CLOSES THE ESCAPE
- SANTĀNA + SĀDṚŚYA PRESERVE CONTINUITY
- MOMENTARY IS NOT NON-EXISTENT

THE CRITERION AND THE DILEMMA

- The real is what can produce an effect, so causal efficacy (arthakriyākāritva) is the test of reality.
- A permanent efficient cause must act all at once, leaving nothing for later production, or successively, in which case it functions differently and has therefore changed.

THE NYĀYA ESCAPE AND ITS CLOSURE

- Nyāya replies that a permanent substance acts when auxiliary conditions (sahakārin) are present.
- The sahakāri-anapekṣā dilemma answers that either the power was already there, making auxiliaries idle, or the auxiliaries supply it, making the permanent thing causally redundant.
- A second line adds that perishing is intrinsic, so no external destroyer is required and destruction cannot be treated as a further caused event.

WHAT SURVIVES THE ARGUMENT

- Apparent persistence is a causal series (santāna) whose members are similar enough (sādṛśya) to be designated as one thing — the flame and the stream.
- Momentariness is established negatively, by eliminating the permanent cause, and never by claiming to perceive momentary phases.

MECHANISM / VERDICT — Nyāya's most effective counter is therefore criterial rather than perceptual, since it refuses to identify reality with causal efficacy and presses that a series cannot own memory or moral desert.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Momentariness is not the claim that nothing exists but the claim that existence is evental rather than substantial, so what a realist calls an enduring thing is a series of causally efficient moments.

06

STAGE 06

NO PERMANENT SELF AND THE FIVE AGGREGATES

- NAIRĀTMYAVĀDA
- FIVE AGGREGATES (PAÑCA-SKANDHA)
- DESIGNATION (PRAJÑAPTI)
- CHARIOT ANALOGY (MILINDA-PAÑHA)
- PUDGALA- VS DHARMA-NAIRĀTMYA
- PUDGALAVĀDA IS A REJECTED FOIL
- THE PERSON IS NOT DENIED

THE ANALYSIS AND ITS TEST

- Form (rūpa) · feeling (vedanā) · perception (saṃjñā) · formations (saṃskāra), where intention (cetanā) sits · consciousness (vijñāna).
- Each is impermanent; what is impermanent and grasped is unsatisfactory; what is impermanent and unsatisfactory is not fit to be 'mine, I, my self'; and no sixth item is found. The exhaustiveness of the list IS the argument.

THE TWO NO-SELVES, PRECISELY DISTINGUISHED

- Personal no-self (pudgala-nairātmya) denies the enduring person and is the shared minimum thesis across Buddhist traditions.
- Phenomenon no-self (dharma-nairātmya) extends the denial to intrinsic nature in the factors and is pressed hardest by Mādhyamika.
- The first dissolves the owner; the second dissolves the inventory on which the owner was denied — which is why the realist schools accept only the first.

SEMANTICS AND THE INTERNAL FOIL

- The chariot analogy shows that a term can be true without naming a further entity, so the person is conventionally valid and not ultimately self-subsistent.
- The Puggalavāda of the Vātsīputrīyas proposed a person neither identical with nor different from the aggregates and was rejected as a relapse toward self-theory.

MECHANISM / VERDICT — The doctrine stands or falls on the completeness of the enumeration, which is why the rejection of the person-theory foil shows that Buddhism accepted the cost of the analysis rather than softening it.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Buddhist no-self is the conclusion of an exhaustive search rather than the premise of a doctrine, and its force lies entirely in the fact that the missing owner is not hidden but simply not there.

07

STAGE 07

CONTINUITY WITHOUT AN OWNER

- NA SA EVA NA CĀNYAḤ
- SANTĀNA (CAUSAL SERIES)
- SĀDṚŚYA (SIMILARITY)
- PRATISANDHĀNA (RELINKING)
- ĀLAYA-VIJÑĀNA + BĪJA
- INTENTION (CETANĀ) CARRIES MORAL QUALITY
- REBIRTH IS NOT TRANSMIGRATION

INTENTION AT t1 -> CONDITIONS STREAM -> FRUIT AT t2 → one lamp lights another: not the same flame, not an unrelated one

THE MIDDLE FORMULA

- The later stage is neither the same as nor another than the earlier one, because strict identity would reinstate eternalism and strict difference would make the fruit fall on a stranger.
- Buddhism therefore denies the disjunction on which the objection rests rather than choosing one of its branches.

EACH OBJECTION AND ITS NAMED DEVICE

- Who remembers? — the causal series, in which an earlier experience conditions a later cognition. Who recognises? — similarity within one stream.
- Who deserves? — the continuous series receives the fruit. What is reborn? — one series relinks to another and nothing travels across.
- What stores latent potential? — store-consciousness with seeds, a conditioned transforming stream and never a disguised self.

RESIDUAL FORCE, STATED HONESTLY

- A series explains succession more convincingly than it explains ownership.
- Buddhism relocates desert to conventional truth and argues that the demand for ultimate desert presupposes the very subject under dispute.

MECHANISM / VERDICT — Moral quality is located in intention, itself a formation among the aggregates, so no bearer beyond the aggregates is required to make an action good or bad.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: The Buddhist account of moral consequence is deliberately a middle, because strict identity would restore the self it has just denied while strict difference would make reward and punishment fall on a stranger.

08

STAGE 08

CESSATION, THE THREE JEWELS AND THE CONSISTENCY PROOF

- NIRVĀṆA — THREE FIRES EXTINGUISHED
- ATTACHMENT · AVERSION · DELUSION
- UNCONDITIONED (ASAṂSKṚTA)
- BUDDHA · DHARMA · SAṄGHA
- PRAJÑAPTI-PURUṢA TAKES REFUGE
- NOT A PLACE, NOT ANNIHILATION
- SAṂSĀRA AND NIRVĀṆA ARE NOT TWO REALMS

A FIRE GOES OUT: it has not gone east, west, north or south — its fuel ended

WHAT CESSATION IS

- Cessation of conditioned suffering extinguishes attachment (rāga), aversion (dveṣa) and delusion (moha), and therefore ends the process that produces suffering.
- Important traditions classify it as unconditioned (asaṃskṛta), which means outside the dependent series rather than a substance bearing properties.

THE FOUR CONSISTENCY MOVES

- The question 'who attains?' already assumes the self that Buddhism denies.
- Cessation is not an entity possessed by a soul; it is the ceasing of craving, ignorance and the suffering-series grounded in them.
- No permanent self removes the false claimant, while momentariness explains why the chain can in fact be interrupted — so the doctrines support one another.

THE THREE JEWELS AND THEIR INTERNAL RELATION

- The Buddha discovered and demonstrated the path, the Dharma is what liberates, and the Saṅgha preserves and transmits it.
- Origin runs Buddha to Dharma to Saṅgha, while access runs Saṅgha to Dharma to Buddha; the refuge-taker is the conventional designated person.

MECHANISM / VERDICT — The surviving objection is Advaitic rather than logical: the unity of experience is answered by refusal rather than by explanation, because a witness would be one more reification.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: The question 'if there is no self, who is liberated?' is not a difficulty but a demonstration of the point at issue, since it presupposes the very claimant whose removal is the liberation.

09

STAGE 09

VAIBHĀṢIKA AND SAUTRĀNTIKA: THE TWO REALISMS

- BĀHYA-PRATYAKṢA-VĀDA
- BĀHYĀNUMEYA-VĀDA
- SARVAM ASTI
- FORM (ĀKĀRA) AND INFERENCE
- PRESENTISM
- BOTH ARE REALISTS
- NOT THERAVĀDA BRANCHES

ISSUE	VAIBHĀṢIKA	SAUTRĀNTIKA
External object	real	real
How known	directly perceived	inferentially known through representation
Temporal ontology	dharmas of past, present and future exist	only present dharmas fully exist
Name derives from	the Mahāvibhāṣā commentary	reliance on the sūtras
Cost	overpopulated ontology; strains momentariness	owes an account of correspondence

THE SAUTRĀNTIKA ARGUMENT

- All conditioned things are momentary; a cause must precede its effect; therefore the object-moment has ceased when its cognition arises.
- Cognition can therefore only bear the object's form (ākāra), and the external object is established by inference rather than by perception.

WHY SARVAM ASTI IS ASSERTED AT ALL

- A past act must be able to bear a future fruit and a cognition must have an object, and both relations need two relata.
- Vaibhāṣika buys these relations by extending existence across the three times, while insisting that present dharmas alone have the distinctive present efficacy.

WHAT EACH POSITION PAYS

- Vaibhāṣika pays in ontological economy and strains strict momentariness.
- Sautrāntika pays with the correspondence problem, which is precisely the joint at which Yogācāra applies pressure.

MECHANISM / VERDICT — This pair supplies the whole 'everything is real' half of the 2024 question, where real means causally efficacious rather than permanent.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: The two Buddhist realisms are separated by a single question with enormous consequences: whether a cognition arriving after its object has ceased can be a seeing of that object at all.

10

STAGE 10

YOGĀCĀRA AND MĀDHYAMIKA: IDEALISM AND EMPTINESS

- VIJÑAPTIMĀTRA
- ŚŪNYATĀ
- ĀLAYA-VIJÑĀNA AND BĪJA
- TRI-SVABHĀVA
- CATUṢKOṬI
- PRASAJYA-PRATIṢEDHA
- TWO TRUTHS BLOCK NIHILISM
- EMPTINESS IS NOT BRAHMAN

YOGĀCĀRA — THREE ARGUMENTS DIVIDED BY FUNCTION

- The dream argument removes realism's evidence, since a complete world-appearance needs no external correlate.
- The atom critique removes its coherence, since partless atoms have no sides with which to combine while atoms with parts are not ultimate.
- The time-gap argument removes its explanatory role, so the inferred external object does no work. Order is restored by store-consciousness with seeds, and the shared world follows from shared karmic conditioning, not from solipsism.
- The three natures — imagined, dependent and perfected — are three descriptions of one flow, not three realities.

MĀDHYAMIKA — THE SIX-STEP DERIVATION

- Intrinsic nature means existing through oneself; the self-existent does not await conditions; everything conditioned does await conditions.
- Therefore nothing conditioned has intrinsic nature; to lack it is to be empty; so the dependently arisen is the empty.
- The four corners are denied only of what is taken as self-established, and the negation is non-implicative, so no fifth thesis is installed.

WHAT KEEPS EMPTINESS FROM NIHILISM

- Conventional truth keeps persons, causation, moral consequence and practice; ultimate truth denies own-being. Conventional truth is not falsehood.
- Emptiness of emptiness prevents emptiness from becoming a hidden absolute, and the snake-wrongly-seized warning marks the danger of misreading it.

MECHANISM / VERDICT — The two conclusions of the 2024 question are not contradictory because the schools apply different criteria of the ultimately real — causal efficacy against independence — to one shared causal premise.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Emptiness is not a thesis about what there is but the refusal of a malformed question, and the two truths exist precisely to stop that refusal from becoming nihilism.

11

STAGE 11

KNOWING, MEANING AND THE SILENCE

- TWO PRAMĀṆAS ONLY
- SVALAKṢAṆA / SĀMĀNYALAKṢAṆA
- KALPANĀPOḌHA + ABHRĀNTA
- APOHA: 'COW' = 'NOT-NON-COW'
- PRAMĀṆA = PRAMĀṆAPHALA
- AVYĀKṚTA — THE UNDECLARED QUESTIONS
- NOT NYĀYA WITH A SHORTER LIST

WHY EXACTLY TWO MEANS OF KNOWLEDGE

- The number of means is fixed by the object-side: the unique particular, which is momentary, causally efficient and ineffable, and the constructed general character, which is expressible and causally inert.
- Perception grasps the first and inference the second; comparison, postulation, non-apprehension and testimony are reduced to them rather than omitted.
- Perception is non-conceptual for Dignāga and additionally non-erroneous for Dharmakīrti, which excludes vivid illusions such as the double moon.

MEANING WITHOUT UNIVERSALS, AND ITS CRITICS

- Exclusion holds that a general term works by excluding the other, so 'cow' functions as 'not-non-cow', grounded in shared causal capacity.
- Kumārila Bhaṭṭa and Uddyotakara charge circularity and the failure to explain positive determination, and that residual force is not fully dissolved.
- Because there is no enduring knower, the instrument of knowledge is not ultimately different from its result, while Nyāya keeps knower, instrument, object and result distinct.

THE SILENCE AND THE CREATOR CRITIQUE

- The undeclared questions concern the eternity and finitude of the world, the identity of life-principle and body, and the Tathāgata after death.
- They are refused as not conducive to the goal, on the arrow parable, and as presuppositionally defective, since all four options assume a substantial subject; the fire-going-out simile shows that directional predication lapses.
- The creator critique is a refusal of explanatory surplus and belongs in one or two evaluative lines, since positive proofs are owned elsewhere.

MECHANISM / VERDICT — Buddhist epistemology is no-self and momentariness translated into a theory of knowledge, which is why it must reduce the means of knowing, deny real universals and finally deny the instrument-result distinction.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: The four undeclared options are the four corners of the later analysis, so the early tradition sets them aside therapeutically while Nāgārjuna later shows logically why they must be set aside.

12

STAGE 12

OBJECTIONS, COMPARISONS AND THE ANSWER RAIL

- ONE COMPLAINT: THE MISSING OWNER
- VĀTSYĀYANA · UDDYOTAKARA · UDAYANA
- KUMĀRILA BHAṬṬA
- ŚAṂKARA-TYPE ADVAITA
- RESIDUAL FORCE IS COMPULSORY
- NEVER 'BOTH DENY THE SOUL'
- NEVER 'EMPTINESS = BRAHMAN'
- GRADED VERDICT, NOT A SUMMARY

FIVE CRITICS -> ONE COMPLAINT -> ONE REPLY: conventional designation on a real series → FINISH WITH: strong as therapy and causation · weak on ownership · contested on desert

FIVE OBJECTIONS AND THEIR NAMED REPLIES

- Nyāya: memory, recognition and desert require a self — reply by causal series, similarity and the flame and river; residual force is ownership.
- Kumārila Bhaṭṭa: self and real universals are required — reply by momentary cognitions and exclusion; residual force is positive determination.
- Śaṃkara-type Advaita: liberation and the unity of the knower need a witness — reply by two truths and self-revealing cognition; residual force is the unity of experience.
- Realist charge: emptiness is nihilism and 'no thesis' is self-refuting — reply by scoped non-implicative negation and the two truths.

CLOSE-OPTION DISTINCTIONS

- Against Jainism: both are non-Vedic and non-creationist, but Jainism affirms a real conscious soul with permanence in substance and change in mode.
- Against Advaita: Advaita's ultimate is positive and self-luminous, while Madhyamaka's is the absence of own-being.
- Against Cārvāka: Cārvāka reduces to body and abolishes rebirth and moral consequence, while Buddhism analyses into aggregates and keeps them.
- Against Nyāya: enduring self, real universals, four means of knowledge and a distinct result, versus momentary particulars, exclusion, two means and instrument-result non-difference.

VERDICT GRID AND ANSWER RAIL

- Strong: the process account of suffering and release, the double middle, the causal-efficacy argument and the two truths.
- Weak: ownership of memory and desert, positive determination under exclusion, and the stability of 'no thesis' without the negation nuance.
- Contested: whether self-awareness proves or reifies, whether empty statements self-refute, and whether a series suffices for moral responsibility.
- Rail: four truths frame, formula, twelve links and the cut, momentariness, aggregates and no-self, continuity, cessation, the school escalation, named objection with residual force, then a qualified verdict.

MECHANISM / VERDICT — A ten-marker needs one cell of the verdict grid, a fifteen-marker one from the strong and weak columns, and a twenty-marker one cell from each of the three columns.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Buddhism is strongest exactly where it is most attacked and weakest exactly where it is most praised, because its causal account of bondage and release is formidable while ownership remains its unfinished problem.

E

EXTRA

SUBORDINATE ENRICHMENT — ONLY AFTER THE COMPLETE CORE

- OPTIONAL ADVANCED DEPTH
- MĀDHYAMIKA INTERPRETATION DISPUTE
- YOGĀCĀRA IDEALISM DEBATE
- PUDGALAVĀDA PRESSURE POINT
- TWO TRUTHS AND ETHICS
- CONTROLLED WESTERN COMPARISON

INTERPRETIVE DISPUTES

- Is Nāgārjuna a quietist dialectician or an anti-essentialist with conventional realism? The Prāsaṅgika–Svātantrika division, associated with Candrakīrti and Bhāvaviveka, marks the dispute internally.
- Does representation-only deny external objects metaphysically or expose how experience is mind-structured? The intersubjectivity objection is answered through latent impressions and shared karmic conditioning.

SECOND-ORDER PRESSURE POINTS

- Could a person-theory secure continuity better than bare aggregate-stream language? Orthodox schools judge the move too concessive.
- If ultimate analysis dissolves self and substance, what secures moral seriousness? The stronger reading places compassion and moral consequence at the conventional level rather than outside it.

CONTROLLED COMPARISON, ONE LINE AT MOST

- Bundle theory, Heraclitean flux, process metaphysics, the antinomies, therapeutic philosophy and nominalism each touch a Buddhist thesis at one point and diverge at another.
- Western parallels are illustrative only and must never replace the Indian argument.

OPTIONAL STATUS — This optional depth is unnecessary for a competent core answer; use it only for added nuance after the complete core has been written.

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